Girl Made of Stars

By Ashley Herring Blake

NOTE: This cutting asks each student to portray multiple characters, which is permissible for Nationals and SOME states. It may not meet the rules requirement for DUO in your state! Be sure to check your STATE rules before performing at local tournaments.

Roles: *Actress – Mara (Owen's Twin), Mom and Hannah (Owen's girlfriend)*
Actor – Owen (Mara's Twin) and Mr. Knoll (Mara's 8th grade math teacher)

OWEN: **(Pg 2)** Once upon a time . . .

MARA: . . . a brother and sister lived with the stars. They were happy and had wild adventures exploring the sky . . . *(to audience)* **(Pg 61)** For as long as I could remember, the storis were a thing with our family. The twins, [Owen and Mara], Gemini soaring through the sky.

OWEN: There were even years when Mom put *Happy Birthday, Gemini* on our cake, little yellow icing stars dotting the chocolate.

MARA: Time passed, we got older and too big and cool to snuggle with Mom for bedtime tales, but we never let go of those stories.

OWEN: They were – are—part of our blood. We were the star twins.

MARA: Owen and I took them over, told new stories as a way to remember we weren't alone. **(Pg 195)** But there's a girl inside of me. Tired. Scared. Lonely. Angry. Devastated. Wounded. She doesn't have a brother.

INTRODUCTION

TOGETHER: *Girl Made of Stars by Ashley Herring Blake*

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

OWEN: **(Pg 30-31)** . . . swear to god, Mom. This is . . . I don't get it.

MOM: He said the state attorney might press charges, Owen. And you're telling me you have no idea why?

OWEN: No! I swear. I'd had a few drinks, yeah, but *(he gasps for breath)*

MOM: Owen, are you sure you asked . . .

OWEN: She wanted to. I swear to god she wanted to. *(his voice raises to a fever pitch)* I'd never do that. I didn't. **(Pg 33)** We had a fight, that's all.

MOM: **(Pg 32)** It's a misunderstanding. Apparently . . . Hannah feels like . . . she thinks . . . Hannah feels that [you] took advantage of her at the lake.

MARA: *(to audience)* **(Pg 97)** The possibility that Hannah is telling the truth never entered my mother's mind. **(Pg 32)** Took . . . ***advantage***? We all know that's not the right word. The word we should be using lunges into my throat. I shove the word back down. There's no way I can say it. There's no way it's really the right word. *(to Owen)* Owen, did you . . . force yourself on her?

OWEN: No! Hell no. You know I would never do that. We had a fight, that's all. *(raking both hands through his hair. He leaves them there, resting his forehead in his palms)*

MARA: I know you wouldn't. I know that. So why would she say you did?

******* flashback*******

MR. KNOLL: **(Pg 19)** Stupid little bitch. Stupid little bitch.

MARA: *(to herself)* Breath in, two three, four . . . breathe out, two, three, four . . . Calm down, Mara . . . *(She squeezes her eyes shut and tries to control her breathing and ignore the words knocking around in her head)*

MR. KNOLL: Stupid little bitch.

****

MARA: **(Pg 93-95)** Owen, what **happened**? I'm listening . . .

OWEN: *(throughout his story, Owen keeps messing with his lip. His voice is the perfect mix of embarrassed and confident)* We were on the trail . . . Anyway, we sat down and

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

started . . . well, you know, kissing and stuff, and then we . . . you know. *(Mara gives him a look)* We had sex, all right? Not like you didn't know what I was saying. Then . . . well she got really pissed. She leaned on her wrist weird or something and she sort of freaked out about it. I told her I was sorry, but she just kept at me. You know how she gets. And honestly, I'm a little sick of her drama.

MARA: *(to audience)* But as I listen to him, watch him, it's as if my skin is peeling away, struggling to reveal this new girl I'm not sure I want to be. It's as though the stars are breaking apart. I know my brother is lying.

MR. KNOLL: **(Pg 19)** Stupid little bitch

****

HANNAH: **(Pg 122-124)** *(her eyes are red-rimmed from crying and her wrist is wrapped in an bandage – she speaks to the audience)* I'm so sorry. . . maybe if I . . . He was so drunk. Everything was fine. We got a drink and danced a little, but he kept going back for more of that punch until I finally convinced him to go on a walk. *(She swallows and licks her lips)* So we started making out, and the next thing I know, we're lying on a bench and it was about to happen and I freaked out. I kept imagining someone walking by. I told him to stop . . . I told him to stop. . . . I'm sorry, I'm sorry, I'm sorry . . . Maybe if I'd said no louder. Or . . . I don't know. I loved him. I trusted him. I never thought he would . . . I don't know if I would've even told anyone if Charlie hadn't found me. . . This is such a mess. **(Pg 203)** Everyone thinks that when someone gets ra . . *(swallows hard and takes a deep breath)* That when someone gets raped, it's this quick, spontaneous thing, always violent with bruises and black eyes. But I guess that's not always the case, you know . . . [It's just] awkward teenage sex.

OWEN: **(Pg 195)** The state attorney called today. They're not pressing charges!

******

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

MARA: **(Pg 97)** This. This is why I never said anything. Because no one ever believes the girl.

MR. KNOLL: **(Pg 19)** Stupid little bitch

MARA: **(Pg 125)** [What about] my own silence, my own fear, my own story? Mr. Knoll and his smug smile, the way he just stood there, totally invulnerable. He held all the power. He could call me a stupid little bitch, and I couldn't do one damn thing about it . . . **(Pg 145)** I am scared all the time. For the past three years, I have a nightmare at least once a week about losing my voice, Mr. Knoll's fingers ripping the vocal cords right out of my throat.

********** flashback to 8th grade – 3 years prior **********

(Pg 185 – 191) *(bell rings to signal the end of class. Mara grabs her backpack and starts to leave the classroom)*

MR. KNOLL: Mara? I need to speak with you for a moment. *(He ushers the rest of the class out the door, closes the door behind the last student and moves to his desk. He rifles through some papers, then looks at Mara with a little smile on his face)* So . . . Mara

MARA: Is . . . is everything okay?

MR. KNOLL: *(sighs)* I'm afraid not. *(he picks up the papers and holds them toward Mara)* Tell me about these.

MARA: *(to audience)* My last three tests, three As circled in red next to my name. *(To Mr. Knoll)* What about them?

MR. KNOLL: *(sighing again)* A student came to me earlier today and said you copied off their tests. *(shaking his head)* This is fixable. I won't fail you if you're willing to put in a little work.

MARA: Fail me? But I didn't. I swear I didn't cheat.

MR. KNOLL: *(shaking his head, his eyes traveling up Mara's legs to her torso)* It's really simple, Mara. I'm disappointed in you, but I know you're better than this. You've

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

been distracted, too focused on summer and high school. . . . [maybe] you'd benefit from repeating the course. *(he brushes her hair back from her face)* Are you willing to work with me on this?

MARA: *(pulls back)* No! I mean, yes, I'll work hard. What do I need to do?

MR. KNOLL: *(inhaling slowly through his nose)* Nothing too difficult. . . come here. *(Mara stakes a step closer)* Good girl. *(he reaches for his belt buckles and undoes it)* I think we can fix this right now, don't you, Mara?

MARA: What are you doing? *(she closes her eyes)*

MR. KNOLL: *(suddenly stern)* Don't do that. Don't be coy. *(He takes Mara's hand and places it on his erection, he moves her hand, forcing her fingers to do what he wants, then speaks in a softer voice).* See? *(breathing heavily)* We're just having fun, right? *(He puts his hand on the back of Mara's neck and pulls her closer)* Soon you can go and have the summer that you planned with your family. You' wouldn't want to ruin that, would you? *(Mara shakes her head as tears stream down her face – she stares at the wall.)* Good girl. *(Mr. Knoll smiles)*

MARA: *(Throws herself violently backward, she trips over her bookbag and scramble to her feet)*

MR. KNOLL: You're a stupid little bitch! *(Mara rushes to the door, manages to get it open and races down the hall)* Stupid little bitch!

****

MARA: **(Pg 230)** That girl is still voiceless, still scared. *(she presses both hands to her forehead trying to calm down)* I know he still works [at the middle school] He teaches pre-algebra and coaches the boys' basketball team. . . **(Pg 231-232)** He's a scumbag and a child molester. What he did is black and white, but dealing with it isn't. He was awarded Teacher of the Year that spring! It never even entered my parents' minds that he might be lying about my cheating. Why the

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

hell would the teacher of the y ear lie about a stupid little girl's tests? No one would believe me. They wouldn't have then. They sure as hell won't now.

MR. KNOLL: **(Pg 19)** Stupid little bitch

****

MARA: *(to audience)* **(Pg 270)** I'm not sure I ever will recover from what Mr. Knoll did. It's changed me forever, but changed doesn't have to mean broken . . . **(Pg 257)** *(whispering)* I'm not stupid. **(Pg 254)** You didn't let it happen, Hannah. You trusted Owen. There's a difference. And with me . . . I didn't let him either. He just took. *(long pause as she collects herself)* **(Pg 270-271)** My brother's and my connection has been altered, never broken but twisted into something I never expected. Never wanted. I have to figure out how to live with that. How to be his twin sister and hate what he did all at once.

****

Owen finds Mara sitting on the front porch alone. He sits beside her and tries to reconnect.

OWEN: **(Pg 260- 262)** Once upon a time . . . A brother and a sister lived with the stars. They were happy and had wild adventures exploring the sky. But lately, Sister Twin was super sad and she felt lonely. So Brother twin decided to collect a bunch of stars and make his sister a crown, and a necklace and a bracelet and a belt and shoes. She was made of stars!

MARA: But if I'm made of stars, then where am I? Where's the real me?

OWEN: See, that's the thing. They thought the stars were sticking to her, but really all the loneliness and sadness were falling off. The stars were underneath all the bad stuff. She just had to remember who she was underneath everything.

MARA: **(Pg 282-283)** Once upon a time . . the brother broke his sister's heart.

OWEN: I didn't . . .

MARA: Don't. Don't you dare!

OWEN: I want things to go back to normal.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

MARA: There is no normal, Owen. Not anymore. . There's only making it something other than this.

OWEN: How?

MARA: Tell the truth.

OWEN: *(offended)* I did.

MARA: Don't you get i? You raped a girl, Owen. You took her choices from her. . . her body, her power. You took her ability to trust, her ability to be with a guy, maybe for years. Do you see how strong she's been at school, despite all that? You're not going to ruin her. I won't let you. **She** won't let you. *(tears run down Mara's cheeks)* **(Pg 286)** *(to audience)* I'm not a girl made of stars. I'm just me, just a girl, just Mara. *(Long pause, then Mara knocks softly at a door)* **(Pg 289)** Mom . . . Dad . . . I need to tell you guys something. *(to audience)* For Hannah. For all the girls whose names I'll never know. . . For me. *(Pause)* **(Pg 294)** There is life after abuse. It's not the same one we had before. But it is still ours. Despite a system and a culture that is perpetually against us, that lets our oppressors go free, that disbelieves our words, there is hope. We are worth the telling. We are worth the fight.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Ashley Herring Blake
ISBN: 978-1328778239
Publisher: HMH Books for Young Readers
Date (Month/Year): May 2018

AWARD HISTORY

2019 National Qualifier

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY